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**IF THE CROWN FITS**
CM Pushkar Singh Dhami being felicitated in Haridwar, Feb. 28

UTTARAKHAND

# How to Win Despite Losing

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

Pushkar Singh Dhami may have lost the election but retained the big prize at the Uttarakhand BJP legislators' meet. On the evening of March 21, amid thunderous applause, he was chosen to continue as chief minister of the hill state. He had lost his Khatima seat to old rival Bhuwan Chandra Kapri by 7,273 votes, creating a blip in what was otherwise a splendid victory for the party. By all accounts, Dhami was the anchor in the BJP scoring a second successive victory with 47 seats in the 70-member state assembly.

Dhami, who is just 46, seems to have the backing of his legislators; at least six of them have already offered to vacate their seats for the second-term CM. The buzz is that the party is looking for a seat in the Kumaon region, either Didihat represented by party veteran Bishan Singh Chuphal or Dhami loyalist Suresh Gariya's Kapkot seat. Meanwhile, sources close to Dhami say they are talking to two Congress MLAs as well to suss out their constituencies. Any 'sacrifice' will not go in vain. The BJP even has to send a Rajya Sabha MP from the state next month.

The party doesn't have a tradition of rewarding politicians who lose polls, so it was a tough decision to make an exception for Dhami. The state unit fully backed him, which made it easier for Dhami to convince the party high command. In the past, Himachal Pradesh's Prem Kumar Dhumal had to make way for Jai Ram Thakur after he was defeated in his Sujanpur assembly segment in 2017.

The party had made an exception for Smriti Irani in 2014, inducting her into the Union cabinet despite her losing the election from Amethi. Party insiders explain that Dhami's case had merit. He presented himself as a doer, and has been able to take party colleagues along in an otherwise deeply factionalised state unit. The party had also built a poll narrative around his age, sought the vote for "a young leader and his young cabinet". The BJP did consider other names, including Rajya Sabha MP Anil Baluni, ex-CM Gen. B.C. Khanduri's daughter Ritu Khanduri Bhushan and former minister and Srinagar MLA Dhan Singh Rawat. But they chose to go with Dhami.

Party leaders were fearful of setting a precedent, given that Dhami had lost the election. In neighbouring Uttar Pradesh, former deputy CM Keshav Prasad Maurya too lost in Sirathu in Kaushambi district. The central leadership is under pressure to retain him. The state has a bicameral system and Maurya is a member of the legislative council. What worked in Dhami's favour is the support of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. There's a general belief that Dhami was the man who helped turn around the party's electoral fortunes in the state. In July last year, Dhami was hoisted into the top spot after the BJP central leadership had dumped Trivendra Singh Rawat and Tirath Singh Rawat in the space of four months.

Dhami, who was sworn in on March 23, is now the first chief minister to return to power in the state. His first challenge will be appointing a fresh cabinet and ensuring that infighting within the state BJP does not affect the government's performance. The state's economy is in a mess, and it will require all his skills to get many of the projects in the works up and running. Dhami will also have to ramp up revenues to implement the BJP's poll promises including three LPG cylinders free of cost to BPL families and a Rs 8,000 grant to farmers. The youth are looking for job opportunities and now that he has a full five-year tenure, he will have to deliver on this too. ■

## CHALLENGES AHEAD

- **Get a fresh cabinet:** Dhami has to ensure that infighting does not affect governance
- **Revive tourism:** Tourism is the mainstay of the economy, but two years of Covid have decimated sector
- **Poll promises:** CM must find ways to increase revenue to pay for all the promised sops